

Powell 2000 Claude Guide

Powell, G. Bingham Jr. *Elections as Instruments of Democracy:
Majoritarian and Proportional Visions.*
New Haven: Yale University Press, 2000.

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1 Central Claims

- Elections are the defining institution of modern democracy, but different electoral systems embody fundamentally different **visions** of what elections are supposed to accomplish—they are not neutral mechanisms but normative commitments about what democracy means.
- The **majoritarian vision** holds that elections should produce a clear winner with a mandate to govern, concentrating power in a single accountable government that can be rewarded or punished by voters at the next election. Clarity of responsibility is the central value.
- The **proportional vision** holds that elections should translate the full distribution of citizen preferences into legislative representation as accurately as possible, with policy emerging from bargaining among diverse groups. Breadth of representation is the central value.
- These two visions generate systematically different institutional designs: **plurality/majority electoral rules** (UK, Australia, France) tend toward two-party systems, single-party majority governments, and concentrated accountability; **proportional representation (PR) rules** (most of Western Europe) tend toward multi-party systems, coalition governments, and dispersed representation.
- Neither vision is simply superior: majoritarian systems excel at **accountability**—voters can clearly identify who is responsible for policy outcomes and act on that judgment—while proportional systems excel at **representation**—policy positions of governments more closely track the preferences of the median voter and minority groups.
- **Citizen-government policy congruence**—the degree to which the ideological position of the government matches the ideological position of the median voter—is systematically higher under proportional systems across Powell’s cross-national sample.
- **Voter turnout** is consistently higher in PR systems, suggesting that more citizens feel their participation is meaningful when representation is more proportional.
- **Citizen satisfaction** with democracy does not differ dramatically between the two types, suggesting that both visions can generate legitimacy, though the sources of satisfaction differ.
- Electoral system design is not exogenous: the choice between majoritarian and proportional rules reflects prior political settlements, the interests of founding parties, and historical contingency—making electoral reform politically contested and path-dependent.
- The framework challenges the assumption that any single institutional design is universally optimal; the right system depends on which democratic values a society prioritizes: concentrated accountability or inclusive representation.

2 Core Case Studies

- **United Kingdom:** The paradigmatic majoritarian case. Single-member plurality elections regularly produce single-party majority governments with strong mandates; accountability is clear, but governments are frequently elected with less than a majority of votes, and significant minorities are unrepresented in parliament.
- **Sweden:** A leading proportional case. Multi-party PR elections produce coalition or minority governments whose ideological positions track median voter preferences closely; high turnout and policy congruence characterize the system, though accountability is diffused across coalition partners.
- **Germany:** Cited as a mixed system—the mixed-member proportional (MMP) design combines single-member districts with a compensatory PR tier, producing broadly proportional outcomes while retaining geographic representation. Coalition governments are the norm.
- **Netherlands:** An extreme PR case with a very low electoral threshold; highly proportional representation but often complex multi-party coalition negotiations, illustrating the tradeoff between inclusiveness and governability.
- **France:** The two-round majority system produces majoritarian outcomes similar to the UK despite a more fragmented party system in the first round; used to illustrate how runoff rules can manufacture majorities.
- **Australia:** Preferential (alternative vote) system; produces majority winners without plurality distortions, offering a variant of the majoritarian vision with higher preference aggregation.
- **New Zealand:** A key natural experiment—switched from plurality to MMP in the mid-1990s, allowing before-and-after comparison of how electoral reform changes party systems, government composition, and policy congruence.
- **United States:** Used sparingly given its presidential system, but cited as an extreme majoritarian case where single-member districts severely underrepresent third parties and minority preferences.
- **Israel:** Cited as a case of extreme proportionalism, with very low thresholds producing highly fragmented parliaments and difficult coalition-building—illustrating the limits of the proportional vision in the absence of any aggregating mechanisms.
- **Denmark and Norway:** Used as examples of successful proportional systems with moderate party fragmentation, high policy congruence, and high citizen satisfaction, representing the proportional vision working well in practice.

3 Core Works Cited

- **Arend Lijphart**, *Democracies* (1984) and *Patterns of Democracy* (1999)—the foundational comparative framework distinguishing majoritarian (Westminster) from consensus democratic models; Powell’s two visions map directly onto Lijphart’s typology, though Powell focuses more on electoral mechanisms and policy congruence.
- **Anthony Downs**, *An Economic Theory of Democracy* (1957)—the median voter theorem and spatial model of party competition; Powell uses the left-right placement of voters and governments to operationalize policy congruence.
- **Douglas Rae**, *The Political Consequences of Electoral Laws* (1967)—the foundational systematic study of how electoral rules shape party systems and representation; Powell builds directly on this tradition.
- **Gary Cox**, *Making Votes Count* (1997)—on strategic voting and the strategic logic by which electoral systems shape party systems; provides micro-foundations for the cross-national patterns Powell observes.
- **G. Bingham Powell and Guy D. Whitten**, “A Cross-National Analysis of Economic Voting” (1993, *AJPS*)—Powell’s own prior work on clarity of responsibility and economic voting; directly informs the accountability chapter.
- **Giovanni Sartori**, *Parties and Party Systems* (1976)—on party system typologies and the logic of party competition; background for the analysis of how electoral rules shape the number and nature of parties.
- **Maurice Duverger**, *Political Parties* (1954)—Duverger’s Law (plurality rules tend toward two-party systems, PR toward multi-party); the empirical foundation of the electoral systems literature that Powell extends.
- **Cees van der Eijk and Mark Franklin** (eds.), *Choosing Europe?* (1996)—cross-national survey data on voter preferences and party placements used to operationalize policy congruence.
- **Andre Blais and R.K. Carty**, “Does Proportional Representation Foster Voter Turnout?” (1990, *European Journal of Political Research*)—on the relationship between electoral systems and turnout, foundational for Powell’s turnout analysis.
- **Christopher Anderson and Christine Guillory**, “Political Institutions and Satisfaction with Democracy” (1997, *APSR*)—on how institutional context shapes citizen satisfaction with democracy; directly cited in Powell’s evaluation of the two visions.
- **John Huber and G. Bingham Powell**, “Congruence Between Citizens and Policy-makers in Two Visions of Liberal Democracy” (1994, *World Politics*)—Powell’s prior article-length version of the policy congruence argument; the book extends this analysis.

- **Rein Taagepera and Matthew Soberg Shugart**, *Seats and Votes* (1989)—on the systematic relationship between electoral formulas and the proportionality of seat–vote translations; technical foundation for Powell’s measurement of proportionality.
- **Samuel Huntington**, *Political Order in Changing Societies* (1968)—background on institutionalization and political development; implicit in the discussion of how electoral rules shape the institutionalization of party competition.
- **Russell Dalton**, comparative public opinion and party identification data—used for voter placement on left-right scales in the policy congruence analysis.

4 Chapter 1: Elections as Instruments of Democracy

- **The book’s animating question:** What should elections accomplish? This seems obvious, but Powell argues that different democracies give systematically different answers—and that these answers are institutionalized in electoral rules and governmental structures.
- **Elections as the central institution:** In all modern democracies, competitive elections are the primary mechanism connecting citizens to government. But elections do not speak for themselves—their meaning depends on the institutional context in which they operate.
- **Two distinct purposes:** Powell identifies two major functions that elections can serve:
 - **Representation:** translating citizen preferences into governmental composition and policy as accurately as possible.
 - **Accountability:** enabling citizens to reward or punish governments for past performance by making it clear who is responsible for outcomes.
- **The tension between functions:** These two functions are in tension. Accountability is clearest when power is concentrated (easy to identify who to blame); representation is broadest when power is dispersed across many parties (easier to include diverse preferences). Electoral systems differ in how they resolve this tension.
- **Scope and method:** Powell draws on a comparative sample of approximately 20 established democracies in Western Europe, North America, and beyond, using both cross-national statistical analysis and case-level narrative. The book bridges large-N empirical work with institutional theory.
- **The dependent variables:** Powell focuses on three ultimate outcomes—**policy congruence** (do governments represent median voters?), **accountability** (can voters effectively control governments?), and **citizen satisfaction** (do citizens find the system legitimate and responsive?).
- **Roadmap:** The book proceeds by first characterizing the two visions theoretically, then examining how they are instantiated in different electoral and governmental systems, then evaluating the performance of each vision on the three outcome dimensions.

5 Chapter 2: Two Visions of Democracy

- **The majoritarian vision defined:** In the majoritarian conception, elections are instruments for *choosing a government*. The ideal sequence is: citizens vote, a majority wins, the majority party forms a single-party government, the government implements its mandate, voters evaluate performance, and at the next election they reward or punish the government. Power is concentrated to make this cycle function cleanly.
- **Institutional logic of majoritarianism:** To produce this sequence, majoritarian democracies tend to feature: single-member plurality or majority electoral rules; two-party systems (via Duverger's Law); single-party majority governments; strong cabinet discipline; a powerful executive; and weak upper chambers or unitary states that prevent veto players from diffusing responsibility.
- **The proportional vision defined:** In the proportional conception, elections are instruments for *representing citizens*. The ideal sequence is: citizens vote, parties receive seats proportional to votes, a coalition is formed that aggregates the preferences of diverse groups, policy reflects bargaining among coalition partners, and the government approximates the median voter's position. Power is dispersed to ensure broad inclusion.
- **Institutional logic of proportionalism:** PR systems feature: multi-member constituencies with proportional formulas; multi-party systems; coalition governments; negotiated coalition agreements; and often bicameralism, federalism, or constitutional courts that further distribute power.
- **Normative roots:** The majoritarian vision derives from a Burkean/Schumpeterian tradition emphasizing decisive leadership and competitive accountability; the proportional vision derives from a Madisonian/consensus tradition emphasizing the representation of minorities and protection against majoritarian tyranny.
- **The empirical question:** Powell does not adjudicate between the visions on purely normative grounds. Instead, he asks: do systems that claim to instantiate each vision actually deliver on its promises? Does majoritarianism produce effective accountability? Does proportionalism produce genuine policy congruence?
- **Neither vision is purely realized:** Actual democracies fall along a continuum between the two ideal types—no system achieves perfect accountability or perfect representation. The analytic framework helps identify where systems fall and what tradeoffs they embody.

6 Chapter 3: Electoral Systems and Party Systems

- **The mechanical and psychological effects of electoral rules:** Following Duverger, Powell distinguishes between the **mechanical effect** (how electoral formulas translate votes into seats, which directly produces disproportionality) and the **psychological effect**

(how anticipation of these translations leads voters and parties to behave strategically, producing further concentration).

- **Proportionality as a continuum:** Electoral systems vary in how proportionally they translate votes into seats, from highly disproportional systems (single-member plurality) to highly proportional ones (large-district list PR). Powell measures this variation using standard proportionality indices across the country sample.
- **Effective number of parties:** More proportional systems produce more parties in parliament (consistent with Duverger), measured by the effective number of legislative parties (Laakso-Taagepera index). This party system fragmentation is the primary intermediate variable between electoral rules and government formation.
- **District magnitude:** The key structural variable is district magnitude (the number of seats per constituency). Higher magnitude increases proportionality; single-member districts produce maximum disproportionality. Thresholds and formula type also matter but district magnitude is the dominant driver.
- **Strategic voting and wasted votes:** In plurality systems, voters in districts where their preferred party has no chance of winning face strong incentives to vote strategically (for a lesser evil); this depresses third-party vote shares and inflates the effective vote of front-runners, compounding the mechanical disproportionality.
- **Empirical patterns:** Powell documents that across his sample, plurality systems consistently produce effective numbers of legislative parties near 2–3 and significant disproportionality, while PR systems produce effective numbers near 4–7 and much greater proportionality. Mixed systems fall between.
- **Implications for government formation:** Higher fragmentation under PR means that single-party majority governments are rare; coalition governments are the expected outcome. This drives the subsequent analysis of how representation and accountability differ between government types.

7 Chapter 4: Forming Governments

- **From elections to governments:** Electoral outcomes do not directly produce governments; the government formation process—coalition bargaining under PR, or direct majority formation under plurality—is a critical intervening stage that determines how citizen preferences are aggregated into governing coalitions.
- **Majoritarian government formation:** In plurality systems, the party with the most seats (usually a majority, sometimes not) forms a single-party government without coalition negotiations. The government is directly mandated by the election; the connection between votes and government is tight and immediate.

- **Coalition bargaining under PR:** In PR systems, government formation involves post-election negotiations among parties that typically require a parliamentary majority. The outcome depends not just on vote shares but on party positions, bargaining strategies, institutional rules (formateur selection, confidence votes), and coalition precedents.
- **Pivotal parties and coalition inclusion:** Coalition theory (building on Riker, Axelrod, and Laver) predicts that minimum winning coalitions form around ideologically adjacent parties. Powell examines whether the parties that enter coalition governments are those predicted by the median voter criterion—i.e., whether the governing coalition includes the party controlling the legislative median.
- **The median legislator and the coalition:** A key empirical finding is that under PR, governing coalitions almost always include the party of the *median legislator*—the pivotal party that controls the legislative middle. This gives the proportional vision its claim to policy congruence: by including the median party, coalition governments are constrained toward median voter preferences.
- **Minority governments:** In some PR systems, minority governments govern with parliamentary tolerance but without a formal coalition majority; these are more common in Scandinavia and represent a distinct mode of governing that has different accountability properties.
- **Duration and stability:** Coalition governments are often assumed to be less stable than single-party governments, but Powell (following King et al.) finds that the relationship between government type and stability is more complex; many coalition governments are quite durable, especially in systems with strong coalition precedents.

8 Chapter 5: Citizen-Government Policy Congruence

- **The central test of the proportional vision:** If PR systems truly represent citizen preferences better than majoritarian ones, this should be detectable in **policy congruence**—the correspondence between the ideological position of the government and the ideological position of the median citizen.
- **Operationalization:** Powell measures congruence using left-right placements of both citizens (from survey data) and parties/governments (from expert surveys). The **median voter position** is estimated from citizen surveys; the **government position** is estimated from the weighted ideological position of the governing party or coalition parties.
- **The congruence finding:** Across the cross-national sample, governments in **PR systems are systematically closer to the median voter** than governments in majoritarian systems. This is the book’s most important empirical finding: the proportional vision delivers on its promise of representation.
- **Why PR produces congruence:** The mechanism runs through the government for-

mation findings of Chapter 4. Because PR coalition governments typically include the median legislative party—and the median legislative party tends to be ideologically close to the median voter—PR governments track median preferences more closely than plurality governments, which may be controlled by a party that won a seat majority with a minority of votes.

- **The majoritarian distortion:** In plurality systems, single-party governments can be quite far from the median voter when the seat distribution exaggerates a plurality winner's dominance. The Duvergerian mechanics of seat–vote amplification mean that governments may hold positions distant from the median but still command a parliamentary majority.
- **Dynamic congruence:** Powell also examines congruence over time, finding that PR systems tend to maintain closer government–citizen congruence across electoral cycles, while majoritarian systems exhibit larger swings as government control alternates between parties distant from the center.
- **The representational advantage is real, not trivial:** The ideological distance between government and median voter is not merely a few points on a survey scale—it represents systematic policy differences on tax, welfare, labor market, and social policy dimensions that matter concretely to citizens' lives.

9 Chapter 6: Accountability and Electoral Control

- **The accountability test:** Having shown that proportional systems score better on representation, Powell asks whether majoritarian systems deliver their core promise: **effective accountability**—the ability of voters to identify who is responsible for policy outcomes and to use elections to reward or punish accordingly.
- **Clarity of responsibility:** Building directly on Powell and Whitten (1993), the key concept is **clarity of responsibility**—the degree to which a single actor (government) can be clearly held responsible for policy outcomes. Majoritarian systems concentrate responsibility in a single-party government; PR systems diffuse it across coalition partners.
- **Economic voting as a test:** If accountability works, voters should hold governments responsible for economic performance. Powell tests this by examining whether incumbent governments are punished by voters for poor economic conditions—and whether this relationship is stronger in majoritarian (high-clarity) systems.
- **The accountability finding:** The evidence is mixed but generally consistent with the theory: economic voting is somewhat stronger in majoritarian, high-clarity systems, but the relationship is weaker than often assumed, and PR systems also exhibit meaningful economic voting. Accountability is not the exclusive property of majoritarian systems.
- **Coalition ambiguity and accountability:** Under coalition governments, voters face genuine uncertainty about which party is responsible for policy outcomes—finance min-

isters vs. prime ministers, coalition partners vs. opposition tolerance. This ambiguity attenuates accountability, but the effect is not as large as the majoritarian critique of PR suggests.

- **The turnover dimension:** Majoritarian systems produce more frequent alternations in government control (the “ins” vs. “outs” dynamic is cleaner), but frequent turnover is not equivalent to accountability if voters cannot connect outcomes to specific policy choices.
- **The accountability–representation tradeoff confirmed:** The empirical analysis confirms that accountability and representation are indeed in tension, and that electoral systems involve a genuine tradeoff between them. There is no institutional design that maximizes both simultaneously; the choice is real and consequential.

10 Chapter 7: Voter Turnout and Citizen Evaluations

- **Turnout and the value of voting:** If PR systems represent citizen preferences more broadly, individual voters have stronger incentives to turn out—their vote is less likely to be “wasted” in a hopeless contest, and the legislative outcome more closely tracks their preference. Powell tests whether this logic is borne out in turnout patterns.
- **The turnout finding:** PR systems exhibit consistently **higher voter turnout** than majoritarian systems across the cross-national sample, even after controlling for other determinants of turnout (compulsory voting laws, closeness of elections, income, education). The electoral system effect is substantively significant.
- **Mechanism—wasted votes:** A key mechanism is the wasted-vote problem in plurality systems. In safe single-member districts, opposition voters have weak incentives to participate since their votes cannot affect the outcome. PR eliminates wasted votes—every vote contributes to seat allocation somewhere—increasing the marginal value of participation.
- **Citizen satisfaction with democracy:** Powell examines whether citizens in majoritarian or proportional systems express greater **satisfaction with how democracy works**. Drawing on Anderson and Guillory, the finding is nuanced: *winners* (supporters of the governing party) are more satisfied in majoritarian systems (where victory is more decisive); *losers* (supporters of opposition parties) are more satisfied in PR systems (where they still have legislative representation).
- **No single system maximizes satisfaction for all:** The satisfaction findings reinforce the central theme: majoritarian systems work well for those who win and poorly for those who lose; PR systems spread satisfaction more evenly. Whether a system is “better” depends on whether you weight winners’ or losers’ experiences more.
- **Legitimacy implications:** Both system types can generate democratic legitimacy, but through different mechanisms. Majoritarian legitimacy rests on decisive accountability; proportional legitimacy rests on inclusive representation. Neither has a clear empirical

advantage in aggregate satisfaction scores.

- **Party identification and engagement:** PR systems also tend to produce stronger party identification and more stable partisan alignments, as voters are more likely to find a party closely matching their preferences—a further mechanism supporting higher turnout.

11 Chapter 8: Conclusions—Evaluating the Two Visions

- **Summing up the findings:** Powell’s empirical analysis yields a consistent picture: **proportional systems perform better on representation and turnout; majoritarian systems perform somewhat better on clarity of accountability;** and citizen satisfaction is roughly comparable, though distributed differently across winners and losers.
- **The proportional advantage is real:** The policy congruence finding—that PR governments are closer to median voters—is Powell’s strongest result and the most consequential for evaluating the two visions. On the dimension that arguably matters most (does government policy reflect citizens’ preferences?), PR wins clearly.
- **The majoritarian advantage is real but qualified:** The accountability advantage of majoritarian systems is real but smaller than majoritarian advocates claim. Economic voting is stronger in high-clarity systems, but the difference is modest and accountability under PR is not negligible.
- **The choice is irreducibly normative:** Because the two visions involve a genuine trade-off, the choice between electoral systems is ultimately a normative question about which democratic values to prioritize. Political scientists can clarify the tradeoff but cannot resolve it from empirical evidence alone.
- **The importance of the whole institutional package:** Powell stresses that electoral rules do not operate alone—they function as part of a broader institutional package including government formation rules, party system properties, constitutional structures, and political culture. Electoral reform in isolation may not produce the expected effects if the surrounding institutions do not change.
- **Reform implications:** The findings suggest that societies valuing inclusive representation should move toward PR; societies valuing decisive accountability should maintain or adopt majoritarian rules. Hybrid systems (like MMP in Germany and New Zealand) attempt to capture both but inevitably face tradeoffs in both dimensions.
- **Limits and future work:** Powell acknowledges the study focuses on established Western democracies—extension to newer democracies, presidential systems, and non-Western contexts requires additional work. The operationalization of policy congruence using left-right scales also assumes a single-dimensional policy space that may not capture all relevant dimensions of political conflict.

- **Normative conclusion:** Powell refrains from declaring one vision superior. Both are legitimate expressions of democratic theory; both can generate functioning, legitimate democracies. The contribution of the book is to show empirically what each vision costs and delivers—knowledge essential for informed democratic design.